Industrial Credit and Investment Corporation of India Ltd (ICICI); and the Housing Development and Finance Corporation Ltd (HDFC).

The six personalities are: Sir Sorabji Pochkhanawala, the founder of the Central Bank of India; Sir Purshotamdas Thakurdas, businessman and central banker, whose outstanding and manifold contributions to public life, industry, insurance, and banking made him one of the brightest stars in the Indian firmament in the first half of the twentieth century; Sir Chintaman Dwarkanath Deshmukh, the first Indian Governor of the RBI, whose ascension to the RBI's Governorship was facilitated by Purshotamdas and whose many achievements included his outstanding contribution at the Bretton Woods Conference in 1944; A.D. Shroff, eminent economist and institution builder, who was a prime mover behind ICICI and whose contributions to industry, banking and insurance was immense; H.T. Parekh, development banker par excellence who played a leading role in moulding ICICI (ultimately becoming its Chairman) and who pioneered retail finance for housing when he founded HDFC in 1977; and Raj Kumar Talwar, considered by many to be the best Chairman the SBI has ever had, and who made lasting contributions to the workings of the bank in particular and to banking in general. Though their starting points were different—Sorabji and Talwar were professional bankers; Purshotamdas was a businessman; Shroff and Parekh stockbrokers; and Deshmukh a career civil servant—there are numerous interconnections and common themes which justify a unifying narrative.

The book is divided into four parts, Books I to IV: Each book has a detailed Prologue introducing the personality and his career, including contributions in fields other than banking, since almost all were multi-faceted personalities. While the book is divided into four parts, with each part dealing with a personality/personalities and an institution/institutions, this division is only for the purposes of ensuring readability and not intended as a watertight compartmentalization. For example A.D. Shroff figures prominently in the Bretton Woods Conference which is a part of Book II and Purshotamdas's contribution as the Chairman of the Rural Banking Enquiry Committee (RBEC) is covered in Book III on the SBI. Also, while the narrative of personalities and their contribution generally follows in chronological order (i.e. the eldest first), given the structure of